



D.S.: back to the sign

Not all repeats in music involve going all the way back to the beginning of the piece. Sometimes composers want to send you to a certain point in the piece, which is when dal segno (Italian for “back to the sign”) is used. Dal segno is abbreviated as D.S.



◁ Dal segno al fine (D.S. al fine)

The instruction dal segno al fine means to go back to the segno (sign, shown here) and play until the fine mark, or ending.

◁ Dal segno al coda

Here, play to the end of line two, then return to the sign at measure six. At measure 13 (the double measure), skip to the coda and play the last seven measures as written.

Types of repeats

This musical illustration contains several types of repeats that performers encounter in various pieces of music. Repeat signs save space, and therefore reduce printing and typesetting costs because identical musical segments do not have to be written out.

▽ Repeats 1

To avoid getting lost in a piece with many complicated repeats, always remember the performer should go back to the previous repeat sign or the beginning, whichever is closest.